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Macher Muro die Muger Daal (Fish head cooked with spicy lentil soup)

This lentil soup is one of the traditional food in Bengal. Last weekend I had two fish heads in my fridge. I am personally not too much fond of plain fish head curry. So, I made this dish and it came out really perfect like 'biyebari'. In most of the bengali wedding this dish is must for lunch and everybody loves it. I ate the home made version of this daal twice from my mom. Those times I really didn't find difference because she made it so tasty and this time 'he' didn't find any difference . Lets see how I made this 'daal' and don't forget to try it in your kitchen.



Ingredients

1 cup yellow lentil / moong daal.
2 big fish heads.
Whole spices (1 Teaspoon cumin seeds, 1 bay leaf, 1 dry red chilli, 3 green cardamoms).
1 Teaspoon ginger paste.
Spice powder (1 Teaspoon turmeric powder, 1 Teaspoon red chilli powder, 1/2 Teaspoon cumin powder).
2 Teaspoons garam masala powder.
Half cup mustard oil.
1 Teaspoon extra turmeric powder for 'daal' and 'fish fry'.
Salt and sugar.
2 green chilies.
2 Teaspoons ghee / clarified butter.
Warm water.

Steps

Dry roast the lentil or daal in pan for 10-12 minutes. When you get nice flavour, turn off the heat and let it cool down.
After cooling down, wash the 'daal' properly with water and boil, till it become soft, with a cup of water. Add 1/2 Teaspoons turmeric powder, some salt and 2 pinches of sugar in it. Wash the fish heads and marinate those with some salt and turmeric powder for 20 minutes. Then heat mustard oil in a kadai. Fry the fish heads both sides till those becomes golden in color.
After frying remove those from the oil and let it cool down.
At this point you can break the fish heads into 3-4 pieces.

Now in the remaining oil or you can discard some oil from the pan, add the whole spices.

Saute it.

Then add ginger paste, all the above mentioned spice powder, 1 Teaspoon garam masala and 3 tablespoons of water. Mix it very well for 3 minutes.

Then add the green chilies and boiled daal or lentil. Mix it and add some salt, sugar. If it becomes too thick add some warm water.

Then add the fried fish heads. Cook this for 10-15 minutes.

Before turn off the heat add ghee and 1 Teaspoon garam masala powder.

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Niramish Aloo Torkari

This is a no onion and no garlic recipe. Usually in many 'puja's we make this kind of dishes. 'Potato curry' goes very well with 'luchi', 'paratha', 'kochuri' etc. But last tuesday I tried a new combo with 'bhatura'. Magically we both loved and enjoyed it very much. I learned this potato curry from my mom. She also follow the same recipe for 'niramish aloo dom' and it tastes always good. Try this new combo and I am sure you will love them too.



Ingredients

2 big potatoes peeled and cut into cubes.
1 tomato chopped.
1 Teaspoon ginger paste.
3 green chilies.
Whole spices (1 Teaspoon cumin seeds, 1 bay leaf, 1 dry red chilli).
Spice powder (1 Teaspoon turmeric powder, 1/2 Teaspoon red chilli powder, 1/2 Teaspoon cumin powder).
Salt and sugar.
6 Teaspoons mustard oil.
Warm water.

Steps

Heat mustard oil in a pan.
Add the whole spices in hot oil. If you like you can also add pinch of 'hing' / asafoetida in this stage. Saute it for 30 secs.
Now add the ginger paste and chopped

tomato with pinch of salt. Mix it and cook it for 5 minutes.

When the tomato become mushy add all the spice powder and 1 tsp sugar. Mix it well for 4 minutes.

Add the potatoes and green chilies. Mix this with masala very well for 5 minutes.

Then add some warm water and some salt.

Cook this untill the potatoes are fully done.

Check the seasoning and consistency of the gravy.

Turn off the heat.

Ghugni or Yellow peas curry

This is almost impossible to find them, who does not love street food and specially 'ghugni' from train vendors. But 'ghugni' also plays a different role along with 'nimki' and 'naaru' during BIJOYA dashami. From childhood I am a big fan of my mom's cooking. I think you already understand that this one is also from my mom's diary :-)



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Ingredients

Yellow peas 1 small bowl.
1 big onion finely chopped.
Ginger garlic paste 1 Teaspoon.
1 medium size tomato chopped.
2 green chilies.
Cumin seeds 3 Teaspoons.
Coriander seeds 2 Teaspoons.
One bay leaf.
One dry red chili.
Spice powder (Red chili powder 1 Teaspoon,
Garam masala powder 1 Teaspoon, Turmeric
powder 1 Teaspoon).
Salt and sugar as per your taste.
Warm water.
Mustard oil 6 Teaspoon.
Some chopped coriander leaves.

Steps

Soak the yellow peas overnight into the water or atleast 5 hours.
Add the soaked peas into a pressure cooker with water and give pressure for 10 minutes. Do not make it mushy.
Dry roast 2 Teaspoons cumin seeds, 2 Teaspoons coriander seeds and 1 dry red chilli in a pan for 10 minutes. Let it cool down and then blend it to powder. It is called 'bhaja masala'. This dry masala is must for ghugni.
Now heat mustard oil in a pan.
Add cumin seeds and bay leaf. Saute it for a minute.
Add the chopped onion with pinch of salt. Fry it for 7 mins. Make the onion golden in color. Then add the ginger and garlic paste. Cook it

for 3 minutes.

Add the chopped tomato. Cook it for 5 minutes.

Now add the above mentioned spice powder.

Cook it for 3 minutes.

Add green chilies, salt and sugar. Mix it.

Now add boiled peas along with the water. Mix it for 5 minutes. If the curry becomes dry you can add some warm water.

Cover the pan and cook it for another 10-15 minutes.

Check the seasoning and consistency of ghugni.

When its done add some chopped coriander leaves and 1 Teaspoon of that 'bhaja masala' or dry roast powder. Mix it and turn off the heat.

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Bhatura (with Yeast)

'Chola-Bhatura' is a very popular combo in India and also in many other countries. The origin of this dish is from Punjab. But you can get this combo as street food in Delhi and many other parts of India. I ate and learnt homemade 'chola-bhatura' from my friend Monica, when I lived in New Jersey. Her 'bhatura's always came out very flakey and puffed up. There is nothing but 'super tasty' I can say about her 'chola'. I have already posted that recipe. Last night I made bhaturas with 'niramish aloo torkari' or 'spicy potato curry'. We, two, really loved and enjoyed them. Try this in your kitchen and make your dinner a special one.



Ingredients

2 cups of all purpose flour / maida.
3 Teaspoons semolina / sooji.
2 Teaspoons milk powder.
3 Teaspoons curd / yogurt.
2 Teaspoons of ghee / oil.
1 Teaspoon yeast.
1 Teaspoon sugar.
1/2 Teaspoons salt.
6 Tablespoons of warm water.
White oil for deep fry.

Steps

Add the sugar, salt and yeast into the warm

water. Cover the bowl and let it rest for 15 minutes. Remember, the water should not be hot.

Put the flour in a mixing bowl. Add semolina and milk powder. Mix it.

Add the curd into the flour mixture. Mix it very well.

Put the ghee/oil and again mix the entire thing very well.

Now add the yeast water in the flour. Mix it with your hand and make a soft dough. If you need more water while mixing, add some warm water.

Now knead the dough with the help of your palm for 10 minutes. It will become more smooth.

Apply little oil on the surface of the dough. It will keep the dough moist.

Cover the bowl with a lid and keep it in a warm place for 5 hours. During winter you need to keep it 7-8 hours.

After 3 hours of fermenting the dough should look like this.

Knead the dough once again for 3-4 minutes and put in the same place for another 2 hours.

When the dough becomes fully fermented make lemon size balls out of it.

Dip one ball in dry flour and flatten it to 2-3 inches with a rolling pin. Try to make them oval in shape.

Put it in very hot oil for deep fry. It will puff up.

Remember, the oil should be very much hot.

Fry them one by one.

If the inside of the bhaturas become this net like texture, that means those are the perfect bhaturas.

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Tandoori Chicken

This dish don't need any explanation. Its very popular in India and nowadays all over the world. There was a rumor that without "tandoor/oven" you cannot make tandoori. But believe me today I am sharing "oven method and gas method" of making tandoori chicken. 'Tandoor' means oven made with clay and the heat comes from charcoal. In restaurants the actual tandoor flavour comes when juices of chicken drops on the charcoal, it creates a nice smokey flavour. You will fall in love with this dish. Please give it a try at your home and prove the rumor wrong.



Ingredients

2 Chicken leg pieces.
6 Teaspoons hung curd.
Salt.
2 Teaspoons fresh ginger and garlic paste.
4 Teaspoons mustard oil.
5 Teaspoons store bought tandoori masala or
1 Teaspoon each (roasted cumin and coriander powder, red chili powder, black pepper powder, kashmiri mirch powder, garam masala powder, dry fenugreek leaf powder).
1/2 Teaspoon cornflour.
Some butter for basting.

Steps

Initial Steps

Wash the chicken pieces and make some slits with sharp knife. Pat dry the chicken.
Now take a big bowl. Add mustard oil.

Then add red chili powder, kashmiri red chili powder and tandoori masala (or remaining all the above mentioned powder). Mix it and let it rest for 8 minutes. From this you will get nice red color.

After that put hung curd, cornflour and salt. Mix it very well. Cornflour will help to stick the marination on the chicken while baking.
Now add the chicken pieces. Massage the chicken pieces with masala very well with your hand. Cover the bowl and keep it in refrigerator overnight or atleast 4-5 hours.

Oven method

Preheat your oven at the highest temperature for 10-15 minutes.

Place the marinated chicken pieces on a grill pan and put in the oven for 25 minutes in 450F. Adjust the temperature as per your

oven. Always place the tray on the upper rack.
Then baste some butter on the baked side.
Turn the chicken pieces on other side and follow the same procedure.
To get the smokey flavour put the tray close to the filaments for 3 minutes each side in highest temperature.
Turn off your oven and let it rest for another 5 minutes.
Before serving chicken tandoori, baste some more butter on top.
Gas method
Take a iron skillet / pan. Heat it very well.
Put very little oil and spread all over the hot pan.
Now put the chicken pieces in the hot pan.
Don't overcrowd the pan.
Cook each side for 15-20 minutes in medium high flame. Baste some butter in between.
To get the smokey flavour turn your burner and hold the chicken pieces in direct flame each side for 1 minute.

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Kashmiri Dum Aloo

From my childhood, almost in every bengali wedding I have seen the famous combo of 'koraishutir kochuri' and 'kashmiri aloor dom' in the menu card. There is no question about that combo, it tastes heavenly. This dish is no onion and no garlic recipe but the attraction is its nice red color. You will need different types of spice powder for this recipe. I don't know much about kashmiri cuisin, this was my first try and I just nailed it . I served this curry in dinner with some 'jeera rice' and 'his' reaction was ... Try this in your kitchen and I truly wanna know about your family's response.



Ingredients

10-12 baby potatoes.
1 Teaspoon cumin seeds.
1 bay leaf.
4 green cardamoms.
6 tablespoons of curd.
Spice powder (1 Teaspoon turmeric powder, 2 Teaspoons kashmiri red chilli powder, 2 Teaspoons red chilli powder, 2 Teaspoons garam masala powder, 1 Teaspoon dry ginger powder, 1 Teaspoon fennel powder).
Salt and sugar.
8 tablespoons of white oil.
6 Teaspoonss of mustard oil.
1 Teaspoon ghee / clarified butter.
Warm water.

Steps

Boil the potatoes with skin for 15 minutes.

Then drain out the water and peel the skin. Take a toothpick and poke some holes in them so that they can absorbe the gravy while cooking.
Heat white oil in a pan. Fry the boiled potatoes with pinch of turmeric powder and salt untill golden brown in color.
Remove them from the pan.
Add all the above mentioned powder in the curd and beat it very well. Keep it aside.
Heat mustard oil in a pan.
Add cumin seeds, green cardamoms and bay leaf. Saute it for a minute.
Bring the flame to low and add the curd mixture. Stir immediately with a spatula for 3 minutes.
Cook it for 10 minutes in medium flame.
Then add salt, sugar and some warm water.

Mix it.

Add the fried potatoes. Cover the pan and cook this until the potatoes are fully cooked.

Add one Teaspoon ghee and pinch of garam masala before turn off the heat.

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Macher Jhol

Bengalis make various kinds of fish curry with different types of fishes. The most simple and easy one is 'macher jhol' or fish curry. 'Jhol' means runny version of a curry. This dish is usually served as lunch with steamed rice and we all are fan of it. In 'macher jhol' you can use rohu / katla / tilapia / pomfret / pabda etc. One can add many kinds of vegetables like potato, cauliflower, eggplant, green peas, carrot etc. I always make this dish with potato and cauliflower because of 'him'. He typically loves this combo. According to me, there is only one restriction about this dish. You have to use 'green chilies' only for the heat and flavour. Try not to use red chili powder or dry red chili because it will make a huge difference. So, here is the recipe how I make 'macher jhol' for my family.



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Ingredients

4 fish pieces.
4 pieces of potato.
4-5 pieces of cauliflower.
Half onion thinly sliced.
Half tomato chopped.
1 Tablespoon nigella seeds (kalojeera).
5 green chilies.
2 Teaspoons turmeric powder.
Half Teaspoons roasted cumin powder.
Salt and sugar.
Half cup of mustard oil.
Warm water.

Steps

Wash the fish pieces very well and then marinate them with some salt and 1 Teaspoon turmeric powder for 15 minutes.
Heat oil in a kadai or pan. Fry the vegetables for 5 minutes in hot oil. Remove them in a plate.
Then add the marinated fish pieces one by one in hot oil.
Fry both side of them for 5 minutes. Then remove it from the pan. You can also keep them on a paper towel, it will absorb the extra oil. While frying the vegetables do not make them dark in color.
In the same hot oil add nigella seeds and 2

green chilies. Saute them. If you prefer to cook in less oil then remove some oil from the pan. But do not change the oil otherwise the taste will differ.

After a minute add sliced onion and pinch of salt. Fry them for 4 minutes in medium flame.

Do not make the onion dark in color.

Then add chopped tomato, pinch of salt, 1 Teaspoon turmeric powder, 1 Teaspoon cumin powder and half Teaspoon sugar. Mix it very well in low flame for 5 minutes.

When the oil starts separating add some warm water and 3 green chilies. Mix it well. If you like more heat, you can add more green chilies. Try to avoid red chili powder or dry red chili for this recipe only.

After 2 minutes add the fried vegetables. Cook this for 8 minutes.

Then add the fried fish pieces. Mix gently with spatula and cook it for another 5 minutes.

Check the seasoning and if you want more curry add some warm water.

Turn off the heat and rest it for 5 minutes.

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Simple Aloor Dom

Bengalis are always very fond of 'peas kochuri' and 'aloor dom' (Dum Aloo) during winter. In Texas, the temperature starts falling as we approach towards the winter time. I already took out light blankets, full sleeves and light sweaters. Last weekend 'he' begged me for 'kochuri-alurdom' and here is the result ... I have already posted one recipe of 'aloor dom' which we can make for party or any special occasions. But this one, you can eat anyday with 'luchi', 'paratha', 'daalpuri' and very easy to make. Try this in your kitchen and don't forget to share your winter story with us.



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Ingredients

10 baby potatoes.
1 cup onion slices.
1 inch ginger.
2 big cloves of garlic.
Half cup chopped tomato.
1 Teaspoon cumin seeds.
1 bay leaf.
1 dry red chili.
Spice powder (2 Teaspoons turmeric powder,
1 Teaspoon red chili powder, 2 Teaspoons
garam masala powder).
2 green chilies.
7 tablespoons of mustard oil.
Salt and sugar.
Warm water.

Steps

Peel the skin and wash the potatoes properly. Make a smooth paste of onion, ginger, garlic and tomato with little water. Keep it aside. Heat 3 tbsps of oil in a pan. Add potatoes, 1/2 Teaspoon salt and 1 Teaspoon turmeric powder. Mix it and fry it for 5 minutes. Remove them from the pan and heat remaining oil. Add cumin seeds, bay leaf and dry red chili in hot oil. Saute it for a minute. Then add the smooth paste. Cook it for 10 minutes. Then add spice powder, salt and pinch of sugar. Mix and cook it for another 5 minutes. Add the fried potatoes and green chilies. Mix

those very well.

Add some warm water. Cook it for 20 minutes.

When the potatoes become tender then turn off your heat.

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